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Effects of Word-of-Mouth Textual Consistency on Consumers' Purchase Behavior

Jiwen Li^a and Dewen Liu^b

^aNingbo University of Finance and Economics; ^bNanjing University of Posts and Telecommunications

ABSTRACT

Based on cognitive evaluation theory, we investigate the process of word-of-mouth (WOM) textual consistency's effects on consumers' purchase behavior in the context of positive reviews. Through an empirical analysis of secondhand data and two experimental studies, we draw the following conclusions: (1) WOM textual consistency has a positive effect on consumers' cognitive trust and purchase behavior, and cognitive trust has a positive effect on consumers' purchase behavior; (2) WOM textual consistency affects consumers' purchase behavior through the mediating effect of cognitive trust, and this mediating process is moderated by brand strength; (3) cognitive trust fully mediates the relationship between WOM textual consistency and consumers' purchase behavior only in the context of high brand strength; (4) brand strength also moderates the effects of WOM textual consistency on cognitive trust and purchase behavior. In this study, purchase behavior is operationalized in two ways: as actual sales in the field study and as self-reported purchase intentions in the experimental studies. Findings in this paper not only deepen the relevant research in the field of WOM but also provide valuable references for enterprises' WOM marketing practices.

Introduction

Word of mouth (WOM) plays a vital role in arousing consumers' purchase behavior since it serves as a key reference for consumers' shopping decisions. Thus, an increasing number of enterprises have begun to encourage consumers to share more positive WOM. For example, the Hilton Hotel offers extra points to consumers who share positive experiences about their accommodations. In WOM research, the importance of word-of-mouth consistency has gained the attention of scholars. Hajli (2019) found that positive WOM valence has a positive effect on purchase behavior, while negative WOM valence has no significant impact on purchase behavior. Huang et al. (2017) believed that the vertical attributes (e.g., restaurant environment) or horizontal attributes (e.g., restaurant taste) with inconsistent WOM valence have mixed effects on consumer behaviors. However, previous studies on WOM textual consistency heavily focused on WOM textual consistency in rating attributes, with insufficient emphasis devoted to the impact of the consistency of WOM text attributes on consumers. In practice, enterprises tend to pay more attention to

the text content of WOM. Dianping.com encourages the original consumption review text content and grants qualified consumers the title of "Orange V." Similarly, top platform enterprises led by Pinduoduo only retain positive reviews with WOM texts and photos on the product review page instead of displaying the specific consumer rating information by default, and WOM texts may become the only source of information for consumer decision-making. Whether and how the consistency of review text attributes affects consumers' cognition and decision-making is the basic question to be answered in this paper.

Meanwhile, the persuasive effects of WOM textual consistency vary depending on the brand. Brand strength can affect consumers' cognitive inferences about a brand (Park et al., 2010). As a result, when confronted with brands with different strengths, consumers' assessment processes are also different. Brands with high strength may lead to more brand dependency among consumers, and WOM textual consistency in this process is regarded as the specific embodiment of brand ability and quality, thereby increasing brand purchase and patronage willingness

(Song et al., 2017). On the contrary, in the context of low brand strength, consumers will externally attribute the positive WOM text, raising concerns about “click farming” (Bone, 1995), which renders WOM texts impossible to “persuade” consumers to buy. As a result, this paper intends to deconstruct the influence mechanism of WOM textual consistency on consumers’ purchase behavior from the perspective of cognitive evaluation theory and to explore the moderating role of brand strength in it.

To sum up, this paper provides theoretical and practical support for existing research in the following aspects: First, this paper extends the research in the field of WOM and explores the effects of WOM textual consistency on consumer behavior at an overall level for the first time. This helps researchers to continue to examine the influence of WOM from the perspective of text. Second, referring to the key idea of cognitive evaluation theory, this paper condenses the mediating variable of the relationship between WOM textual consistency and consumers’ purchase behavior, cognitive trust, which undoubtedly enriches and deepens the related research in the field of consumer cognition. Third, from the perspective of enterprises’ WOM management, this paper discusses how to maximize the positive effects of WOM textual consistency, which also refines the research idea of WOM effects to some extent. For conceptual clarity, we use the term *purchase behavior* broadly; however, in our empirical design, this construct is operationalized differently across methods—measured as monthly sales in the field study and as purchase intentions in the experimental studies.

Literature review and hypotheses development

WOM textual consistency

Word-of-mouth (WOM) textual consistency. Here, we speak more specifically about the level of convergence of the judgments of various consumers concerning a product/service. Early attempts to model this focused on the degree of variation among reviews, with a higher amount of variation indicating inconsistency and a lower amount indicating consensus (Chatterjee & Basuroy, 2006; Zhu & Zhang, 2010). In this type of study, the difference in distribution of ratings, i.e., variance or standard deviation in star ratings, was used as a measure of WOM textual consistency (Chang & Chen, 2009). Classic WOM research studies have demonstrated that both valence (positive or negative tone) and review volume (the number of reviews)

have powerful influences on the sales of individual products and consumer trust (Chevalier & Mayzlin, 2006; Floyd et al., 2014; King et al., 2014). Moreover, according to Clemons et al. (2006), a positive correlation has been discovered between credibility and trust based on the consensus of reviews, where inconsistency induces uncertainty in the consumer perception.

In addition to a numerical rating, scholars have come to appreciate the significance of the text content of reviews. As consumers often use review narratives to infer the quality of products, it is imperative that the trustworthiness of textual data can be achieved through consistency across a variety of reviews (Walther et al., 2012). Studies of the review redundancy and informativeness show that slightly duplicated but concise information enhances a sense of credibility, whereas a significant degree of redundancy decreases informativeness and causes consumers to doubt it (Filieri, 2015; Mudambi & Schuff, 2010). Fake review detection studies relate to the fact that shoppers are tuned in to trends of unnatural uniformity concerning fake reviews that are excessively normal (Luca & Zervas, 2016). The discovery points out that textual alignment can be bilateral in that it may establish trust because of consistencies, but also arouse suspicions in that it may be perceived as falsified.

Recently, there has been work that has distinctly dealt with valence consistency and similarity in reviews. An example of such results can be seen in the studies by Quaschnig et al. (2015, 2017), which verified the effects of consistent valence on the usefulness of the reviews, showing that consistent valence had positive effects. In contrast, inconsistent valence lowered the usefulness of reviews. Walther et al. (2012) use congruity theory to reveal that congruent cues found across several texts heighten credibility and low uncertainty in consumer processing. These studies indicate that textual consistency as a construct exists besides rating variance and review valence, which tend to be of concern.

In short, even as research on WOM textual consistency has been substantial, there has been a dearth of studies that have systematically studied textual consistency—that is, whether review narratives remain consistent or not. Based on current evidence, it is known that aligned reviews with identical words, topics, or content create a higher level of processing fluency and credibility that leads to assessments and predispositions to buy (Shen et al., 2018). Possible boundary conditions have also been provided in the literature, including consumer mistrust of artificially consistent reviews and the mediating effect of

brand-related factors. Against this background, our research adds an innovative twist by building and empirically testing a model of how WOM textual consistency influences consumer trust and purchase behavior and how this is moderated by brand strength.

Theory foundation

How consumers process WOM information can be viewed as a two-step process of appraisal and coping. Based on cognitive appraisal theory (Lazarus, 1986), human beings interpret external events in terms of their significance to personal aspirations (primary appraisal) and how to act accordingly (secondary appraisal). In the WOM context, upon exposure to review texts, consumers initially evaluate the information based on its credibility, usefulness, and overall compatibility with their expectations. They will then take coping action, including the decision to trust the brand, follow it further, or proceed with the purchase based on this kind of appraisal.

One of the critical appraisal results of this process is cognitive trust. Cognitive trust is the considered opinion that another entity (e.g., a brand) is competent, reliable, and capable of following through on its claims (Morgan & Hunt, 1994). In contrast to affective trust, which comes as a result of emotional connections, the cognitive form of trust becomes possible because of the objectively based judgment of the quality and consistency of the information. As perceived by the consumers, an increase in WOM text consistency leads to a drop in uncertainty and rising confidence in the brand, boosting cognitive trust. On the other hand, inconsistent WOM texts can make consumers feel more ambivalent and undermine their trust in the stability of the brand.

This appraisal-coping mechanism is also composed of cognitive consistency principles. Studies over the past decades indicate that people act to create consistency between what they know and follow-up actions (Festinger, 1957; Walther et al., 2012). When consumers have a positive cognitive appraisal of a brand due to consistent WOM, they feel motivated to behave in a way that is congruent with the cognition, most saliently through purchase behavior. In this way, WOM textual consistency contributes to the shaping of the initial judgments but also downstream behaviors, with the need to align cognitively and behaviorally.

Collectively, the theoretical rationale of appraisal and consistency point to how WOM textual consistency creates an external prompt sufficient enough to trigger a series of events, viz, appraisal of review

information\(->\), building of the cognitive trust\(->\), and coping through the manifestations of purchase actions. Simultaneously, it is not even enacted in a generalized manner. The brand strength will interact with WOM cues that influence how consumers evaluate and interpret text in reviews. Having strong brand names may be advantageous in terms of positive appraisals when there is WOM textual consistency. In contrast, weak brands may be suspicious even when there is consistency in review texts. This is why we have considered incorporating brand strength as one of the moderating factors in our model.

Theory development

Building on this theoretical foundation, this section develops our research model by specifying the relationships among WOM textual consistency, cognitive trust, brand strength, and purchase-related outcomes, leading to the formulation of testable hypotheses.

WOM textual consistency and cognitive trust

Individuals prefer relatively consistent information and give more weight to details with high similarity (Sun et al., 2014). Unlike image information, text information is more complex, and its processing requires a lot of cognitive resources. Therefore, in the process of cognitive evaluation of WOM texts, consumers rely more on the similarity between texts to judge the authenticity of WOM information. If WOM texts are consistent, consumers perceive a lower level of uncertainty when processing information (Wimmer & Yoon, 2017), leading to a favorable initial evaluation of the brand. If WOM texts are highly inconsistent, consumers find it hard to judge the authenticity of information and the quality of products through WOM, which weakens consumers' cognitive confidence in the trustworthy party of WOM in the process of cognitive evaluation. In addition, in the context of positive reviews, consistent WOM texts increase consumers' diagnostic cognition regarding WOM texts (Quaschnig et al., 2015), thereby directly having a positive effect on their purchase behavior. Based on the above theoretical framework and literature review, we propose the following hypotheses to test the impact of WOM textual consistency on consumers' cognitive trust and purchase behavior, as well as the mediating role of cognitive trust and the moderating role of brand strength.

H1: WOM textual consistency has a positive effect on consumers' cognitive trust.

H2: Consumers' cognitive trust has a positive effect on their purchase behavior.

H3: WOM textual consistency has a positive effect on consumers' purchase behavior.

H4: Consumers' cognitive trust mediates the relationship between WOM textual consistency and purchase behavior.

H5: The positive effect of WOM textual consistency on cognitive trust is stronger for high-strength brands than for low-strength brands.

H6: The indirect effect of WOM textual consistency on purchase behavior through cognitive trust is significant for high-strength brands but not for low-strength brands.

Cognitive trust and purchase behavior

Trust was identified long ago to be one of the central processes connecting information processing to consumer behavior (Morgan & Hunt, 1994). In online WOM, there are specific types of trust, namely the cognitive type and the affective type of trust (McCallister, 1995). Cognitive trust is based on rational judgment, as it feels that such a brand is competent, reliable, and capable of doing what it has promised. In comparison, affective trust is based on an emotional connection to or attachment with a brand, whereas general brand trust may have both aspects (Punyatoya, 2019).

Cognitive trust is of relevance to consumers who have been exposed to online reviews. Consumers in digital spaces tend to engage in a one-dimensional approach to information processing, where opportunities to interact with brands are scarce. In this situation, they will form major decisions based on cognitive judgments, including, among other things, the level of trust and credibility of a brand as perceived through reviews. Previous studies have established that cognitive trust decreases uncertainty when making an online decision and helps promote the likelihood of buying (Filieri, 2015; Zhu & Akhtar, 2014). WOM textual consistency is another type of external stimulus in the suggested framework, which will influence this process of rational evaluation. The texts are written more consistently, thus the consumers find less uncertainty and greater credibility, concluding that the brand is reliable. This increases mental confidence, which, consequently, increases their intentions to buy. On the other hand, inconsistent WOM messages lead to ambiguity in evaluating a brand by

consumers, which in turn decreases the propensity to purchase the product.

We know, therefore, that cognitive trust mediates the associations between textual consistency and buying behavior in WOM. This selection of mediators is theoretically accurate as it encompasses why consumers have a reasoned assuredness that the brand is competent cue that directly mediates between the consideration of review information and subsequent purchase behavior.

The moderating role of brand strength

Brand strength refers to the degree of consumers' cognition of brand attributes and characteristics (Wang et al., 2017). From the perspective of cognitive evaluation theory, brand characteristics interact with external information, and they jointly affect individuals' evaluation results. Specifically, brand strength affects individuals' inferences about brand-related information. As for strong brands (those with high brand strength), due to their favorable position and image in the minds of consumers, consumers are more inclined to associate the consistent positive reviews with the brands themselves after being exposed to external stimulation with high WOM textual consistency (Chen & Lurie, 2013). For example, strong brands' standardized products or service processes make consumers converge when writing WOM texts. As for weak brands (those with low brand strength), however, due to the lack of external information, consumers are naturally skeptical of these brands and then tend to attribute positive reviews with high textual consistency of these brands to external reasons (e.g., posting positive reviews to gain a bonus, click farming, etc.), thus weakening the effects of WOM textual consistency on cognitive trust. Based on the above analysis, this paper argues that brand strength can moderate the cognitive trust's mediating effect in the entire influence process. That is, brand strength reinforces consumers' cognitive evaluation process of WOM textual consistency.

To sum up, the research framework of this paper is shown in Figure 1.

Empirical analysis

Research design

In the preliminary study before the two experimental studies, an empirical analysis is first performed using data scraped from the takeout app Ele.me, including reviews and sales. The reasons why takeout is selected as the research object are as follows: First, the online

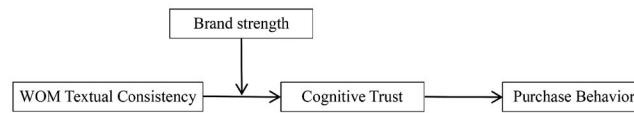


Figure 1. Research model.

Table 1. Descriptive statistical results of variables.

Variable	N	Mean	Std. dev.	Min	Max
WOM textual consistency	121	0.330	0.130	0.074	0.495
Whether the store is branded	121	0.512	0.502	0	1
Whether the takeout can be taken	121	0.537	0.501	0	1
Whether the insurance is available	121	0.793	0.407	0	1
Whether the invoicing is available	121	0.851	0.357	0	1
Rating	121	4.577	0.205	4.1	4.9
Sales	121	1,072	459.902	372	1,949
Number of WOM	121	1,070	551.502	7	2,484

WOM of takeout is an important factor affecting consumers' shopping choices (Zhang, 2020). Second, in real life, many takeout stores pay money to buy positive reviews, which is conducive to the validation of the research hypotheses in this paper. Third, the Ele.me app's default order of displaying store WOM reviews is the stores' positive reviews first, rather than in chronological order, and consumers cannot see the store's negative reviews unless they actively click on the recent positive reviews or keep sliding, which is more in line with the research contexts of this paper.

Data collection

In this field study, we operationalized *brand strength* using the Ele.me platform's distinction between branded vs. non-branded stores, which serves as a practical proxy for strong vs. weak brands. On July 20, 2021, this paper randomly scraped the current takeout data of 121 different types of restaurants and gourmet shops in a business district in East China from Ele.me, including the name of each takeout store, whether consumers can take takeout, whether the invoicing is available, whether the store is branded, store reviews, text information of reviews, monthly sales, etc. Due to the huge number of reviews in each store and the fact that the default order of review display is not in chronological order, this paper only compares the first 10 reviews with the previous reviews for analysis to more authentically restore consumers' decision-making process. When making takeout consumption decisions, consumers use fewer cognitive resources, and individuals have a short-term memory of about 30 seconds to 2 minutes (Mu et al., 2013). Therefore, the number of 10 reviews is consistent with the cognitive processing capacity of individuals' short-term memory. The auxiliary words, adverbs, and modal particles in the review texts are

removed in the formal analysis, and Python is adopted to compute the Jaccard similarity between each review and the other nine review texts, namely:

$$d_j(A, B) = 1 - J(A, B) = \frac{|A \cup B| - |A \cap B|}{|A \cup B|}$$

In this paper, the mean of the 10 Jaccard similarity indices is used as an alternative variable for WOM textual consistency. In terms of brand strength, this paper believes that brand mapping reflects brand value and image and is a stable brand value projection of brands in consumers' minds (French & Smith, 2013). Therefore, whether the store is branded (e.g., KFC and McDonald's are branded stores) is taken as an alternative variable of brand strength, and consumers can identify this through the store icons when ordering takeout. Because the mediating variable of cognitive trust cannot be measured, only the dependent variables are studied. As to consumers' purchase behavior, this paper uses monthly sales as its alternative variable due to a lack of direct access to consumers' purchase behavior.

Data analysis

As shown in Table 1, descriptive statistical analysis suggests that the data distribution of several key variables is representative. We then conducted linear regression analysis to test the effects of WOM textual consistency on product sales and the moderating role of brand strength. Then, linear regression analysis is used to test the impact of WOM textual consistency on product sales and whether brand strength moderates the relationship between WOM textual consistency and product sales. The test results are shown in Table 2. In model 1, the effect of WOM textual

consistency on sales is 641.24, while this effect is -657.97 in model 2. Besides, in model 2, the interaction effect between WOM textual consistency and whether the store is branded on sales is 3103.11, indicating that brand strength moderates the impact of WOM textual consistency on sales, which is intuitively demonstrated in Figure 2. It can be seen from Figure 2 that, for stores with low brand strength (non-brand stores), there is no difference in the effects of WOM textual consistency on sales. But for stores with high brand strength (branded stores), WOM textual consistency can greatly promote sales. Given the omitted variables problem in the models, i.e., WOM textual consistency may be endogenous, the degree of WOM textual consistency may reflect consumers' preferences for a particular kind of dish. For example, Sichuan cuisine may be more appealing to consumers. However, because it is impossible to figure out the specific dishes that consumers order in each store, due to the endogeneity problem caused by this situation, this paper uses the selection ratio to test whether the omitted variables lead to a deviation in the estimated coefficient of the focus variables. By calculation, the selection ratio of WOM textual consistency is 1.898 (greater than 1).

Table 2. Regression analysis results.

Variables	Model 1	Model 2
Constant term	738.29 (502.54)	459.04 (332.13)
WOM textual consistency	641.24 (179.91)	-657.97 (159.62)
WOM textual consistency $\times$ branded store or not		3103.11 (255.13)
Whether the store is branded	347.98 (53.17)	-585.18 (84.35)
Controls	Yes	Yes
Observations	121	121
R-squared	0.741	0.888

Results and discussion

The empirical results presented above suggest that there is a positive correlation between WOM textual consistency and product sales (an alternative variable of consumers' purchase behavior), and brand strength can moderate this relationship. As shown in Figure 2, WOM textual consistency has a significant role in promoting sales when the brand is a strong brand, but it does not affect sales when the brand is a weak brand. To further confirm the psychological process of consumers' cognitive assessment and increase the robustness of the research, two additional experimental studies are conducted in this paper.

Experimental studies

Study 1

Pretest

Consistent with the preceding empirical analysis, Study 1 continues to use catering sector brands as the experimental stimulus. Two separate pretests are conducted to determine brands that represent different brand strengths, as well as appropriate WOM textual consistency stimulus materials for the later formal experiment.

In the first pretest, 21 undergraduate students were invited to rate the brand image of hotpot brands, including Xiaofeiyang, Xiangtianxia, Haidilao, Daimei, Liuyishou, Xiaolongkan, Principal Lu, Jiudingxuan, and Axiangpo, and the two brands with the highest and lowest ratings were selected as the typical representatives for high and low brand strength, respectively. Haidilao scores the highest ($M=4.52$, $SD=0.60$), while Dai Mei scores the lowest ($M=2.95$, $SD=0.86$). As a result, Haidilao and Daimei are selected for the subsequent formal experiment in Study 1, in which the logo and brand name of the two brands appear at the same time to ensure that consumers can perceive the brand strength.

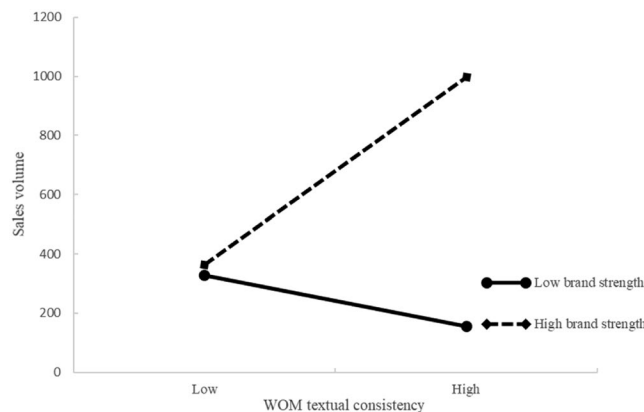


Figure 2. Moderating role diagram for secondary data verification.

Simultaneously, another pretest is conducted to determine the appropriate stimulus materials for WOM textual consistency for the subsequent formal experiment in Study 1. In the previous empirical analysis, the textual similarity distance was used to calculate whether WOM is consistent. To make the experiment more realistic, the real-life WOM data from Haidilao and Daimei stores in the city where the experiment takes place is scraped manually and used to generate experimental materials. Concerning the WOM manipulation method used by Chen and Xie (2008), the five-star reviews regarding two brands on Dianping.com are selected (to exclude the influence of review ratings), among which several reviews that are more consistent in text are picked for re-combination by two research assistants. For example, a review of Haidilao writes, "About eating hot pot, I prefer Haidilao. Good environment. Many condiments. And the taste is OK." A review like the following is considered to have high WOM similarity to it: "For hot pot, Haidilao is my first choice. The environment here is beautiful. There are many condiments. The cuisine is exquisite." And a review like the following is considered to have low WOM similarity to it: "Zhang Han (Haidilao waitress) provided excellent service, peeled grapefruit for me, and gave me snacks and gifts." Consistent with the preceding empirical analysis, 10 reviews are selected for each hot pot brand, and they are revised in combination with the actual situation. Of the stimulus materials with high WOM textual consistency, this paper mainly keeps the service aspects of WOM reviews consistent while keeping the textual similarity and using synonyms for replacement (e.g., "good" replaced by "not bad"). Of the stimulus materials with low WOM text consistency, this paper mainly focuses on WOM review services. Meanwhile, to avoid interference from factors such as hot pot dishes, store location, and per capita consumption, only specific review information is presented in the experiment. Referring to the research of Huang et al. (2017), review ratings, supplemental WOM, merchants' replies, valence, review time, and other factors also affect readers' perceptions. Such information is concealed in the experiment. Finally, a different group of subjects is invited to take part in the pretest of the stimulus materials, and the pretest results are promising.

Experimental design

We tested the impact of WOM textual consistency and brand strength using a 2×2 between subject design. The sample participants were randomly assigned four positions. The WOM stimuli were

review texts manipulated in terms of textual consistency. In both the high-consistency condition and the low-consistency condition, similar descriptors were repeated. Still, in the high-consistency condition, overlapping attributes (e.g., service is attentive, staff are friendly) were emphasized as opposed to in the low-consistency condition, where varied descriptors (e.g., service is attentive, decor is stylish, food variety is rich) were presented with less overlap. They controlled brand strength by using either a strong nationally recognized brand, such as Haidilao, or a weak local brand, such as Daimei. The length and valence of review sets were also matched to isolate the consistency manipulation.

- Cognitive trust was measured using McCallister's (1995) cognition-based trust scale (five items; 7-point Likert scale, 1 = strongly disagree to 7 = strongly agree; Cronbach's $\alpha = 0.84$). A sample item is: "I believe this brand is competent and reliable."
- Purchase intention was measured with a three-item scale adapted from Dodds, Monroe, and Grewal (1991) (7-point Likert scale; Cronbach's $\alpha = 0.87$). A sample item is: "I will consider going to this store in the future."
- Manipulation check questions were included to confirm the effectiveness of both brand strength and textual consistency manipulations.

Demographic variables (age, gender, income, and education) were also collected for descriptive purposes but were not used in hypothesis testing.

In the formal experiment, a 2 (degree of WOM textual consistency: high WOM textual consistency vs. low WOM textual consistency) $\times 2$ (brand strength: strong brand vs. weak brand) between-subjects design is adopted. One hundred forty-three students from a university in East China are recruited to participate in this experiment. One hundred forty-three questionnaires were received, with a 100% return rate. Subjects are instructed to imagine that they are preparing to go to a hot pot restaurant for dinner and make decisions after reading the materials. To ensure the validity of the experiment, subjects are required to read the experimental materials for at least 40 seconds. After unqualified questionnaires with missing answers and blanks are eliminated, 121 questionnaires are finally used for experimental analysis, involving 47 male subjects and 74 females aged 17 to 26 ($M = 19.98$, $SD = 2.30$). The effective response rate is 84.62%, which meets the requirements of general marketing experiments.

Subjects are first asked whether they know the two brands of Haidilao and Daimei. Then the formal experiment begins, which consists of three parts. The first part is about the manipulation of WOM textual consistency. The manipulation of information presentation achieves differences in WOM textual consistency. As mentioned above, the stimulation method in the experiment is a combination of brand logo + copy + WOM information. Four different situations are randomly and equally presented in the questionnaire.

The second part is about measuring the variables. Concerning the research of Liu and Yao (2018), four items are included in the questionnaire to measure purchase behavior. The representative item is “I will consider going to this store for consumption.” Concerning the research of McCallister (1995), a 3-item scale is designed to measure cognitive trust. The representative item is “I think the store and the products it sells are reliable.”

The third part is about the subjects’ personal information and the manipulation effect test of WOM textual consistency, including three items: gender, age, and the effect test. The effect test consists of two parts. The first part is to determine whether the subjects notice the brand in the experiment. After the experiment, the subjects are asked to recall the hot pot’s brands. The second part is to determine whether the stimulation of WOM textual consistency is successful. Subjects are asked to choose between A. WOM information has high consistency, B. WOM information does not have high consistency, and C. Uncertainty.

Data analysis

All survey responses were numerically coded before analysis (e.g., 1 = “strongly disagree” to 7 = “strongly agree”), and only closed-ended measures were used for hypothesis testing. The dataset was not weighted before analysis, as the demographic composition of the sample was consistent with the intended study population. For moderation analysis, we employed Hayes’ PROCESS macro (Model 1) in SPSS 25, using 5,000 bootstrap resamples to estimate confidence intervals. This allowed us to test the conditional effects of WOM textual consistency on cognitive trust under different levels of brand strength. Figure 2 was generated using AMOS (version XX) to present the research model and hypothesized relationships visually. Manipulation checks are first performed. The subjects’ answers to the manipulation checks of WOM textual consistency are entirely correct, indicating that the manipulation is relatively successful.

Secondly, the reliability and validity are tested. Cronbach’s α values for cognitive trust and purchase behavior are 0.891 and 0.827, respectively, both of which exceed the threshold value of 0.7. Then the effect of WOM textual consistency on purchase behavior is analyzed. The results show that WOM textual consistency affects purchase behavior ($M_{\text{low consistency}} = 4.41$; $M_{\text{high consistency}} = 4.88$), indicating that high WOM textual consistency can stimulate consumers’ purchase behavior more than low WOM textual consistency. Then the effects of WOM textual consistency on cognitive trust are analyzed. The results show that compared with low WOM textual consistency, high WOM textual consistency can stimulate consumers’ higher level of cognitive trust ($M_{\text{low consistency}} = 4.32$; $M_{\text{high consistency}} = 5.05$). Finally, a regression analysis of the effects of cognitive trust on purchase behavior is conducted. The results show that the standardized regression coefficient is $\beta = 0.537$.

Then, the moderating effects of brand strength are analyzed. As shown in Table 3, in the high brand strength group, high WOM textual consistency is more likely to promote cognitive trust in comparison to low WOM textual consistency ($M_{\text{low consistency}} = 3.89$; $M_{\text{high consistency}} = 5.31$). In the low brand strength group, the difference in the effects of the degree of WOM textual consistency on cognitive trust is less significant ($M_{\text{low consistency}} = 4.73$; $M_{\text{high consistency}} = 4.78$). At the same time, according to Table 3, brand strength also moderates the effects of WOM textual consistency on purchase behavior.

Finally, the mediating effects of cognitive trust are analyzed. The results suggest that the mediating effect size of cognitive trust is 0.37. In this case, after the mediating variable is controlled, there is no direct effect of WOM textual consistency on purchase behavior. The moderated mediating effect analysis results are as follows: In the low brand strength group, the cognitive trust has no mediating effect; in the high brand strength group, the mediating effect size of

Table 3. Moderating effects of brand strength on cognitive trust and purchase behavior (Experiment 1).

	Partial SS	DF	MS
Dependent variable: cognitive trust (R-Squared = 0.245; Adj. R-Squared = 0.153)			
WOM textual consistency	14.243	1, 117	14.242
Brand strength	0.883	1, 117	0.883
Product term	14.184	1, 117	14.184
Dependent variable: purchase behavior (R-Squared = 0.198; Adj. R-Squared = 0.101)			
WOM textual consistency	7.239	1, 117	7.239
Brand strength	0.737	1, 117	0.737
Product term	4.944	1, 117	4.944

cognitive trust is 0.74. Meanwhile, the moderated mediating effect is 0.73. It can be seen that cognitive trust has a mediating complete impact only in the context of high brand strength, and there is no mediating effect in the case of low brand strength. The manipulation check confirmed the effectiveness of the brand strength operationalization: over 95% of participants reported being familiar with Haidilao (strong brand), whereas fewer than 5% indicated familiarity with Daimei (weak brand). This significant difference confirms that participants correctly perceived the intended variation in brand strength.

Discussions

Through the experiment using hot pot brands as the experimental scenario, the proposed point of view in this paper are further tested based on the verification using secondary data. First, the positive correlation between WOM textual consistency and purchase behavior, as well as the moderating role brand strength plays in the relationship between the two, is verified again. Second, for the mediating mechanism, the mediating effect that cognitive trust plays in the relationship between WOM textual consistency and purchase behavior is verified, and this kind of mediating effect functions only in the context of high brand strength.

Study 2

Pretest

The above empirical analysis and Study 1 are both conducted in the catering scenario, and review ratings (i.e., WOM valence) are concealed in Study 1. To promote research universality, Study 2 is conducted, in which a new scenario, the laundry, is chosen. Firstly, four real brands on Dianping.com are selected. Then, following the same procedures as in Study 1, FORNET and Youyijing are finally confirmed as the representatives of strong vs. weak brands, respectively. FORNET is a famous laundry chain brand, with more than 1,600 franchise stores and more than 230 direct-sale stores in China, while Youyijing is a small brand of private laundry. Meanwhile, concerning the views of Huang et al. (2017), reviews with a rating of 3.8 or more on a 5-point scale are considered positive reviews. Since the focus of this paper is on WOM textual consistency, review ratings should, in principle, be excluded from the experiments to avoid their influence. However, to prove the universality of the research conclusion, specific ratings, user avatars, and user IDs are included in the WOM text

information in Study 2. Reviews on Dianping.com with a rating of 4 or more for the two brands, FORNET and Youyijing, are selected and revised using the same method as in Study 1. All revised reviews, together with the corresponding rating of five or four points, are randomly presented. For example, a review of Youyijing writes that “it is great to get rid of yellow! The boss is perfect (four points),” and one example of WOM reviews with high similarity to it is “all the yellow off the clothes is washed, and the boss’ service is also good (five points),” while one example of reviews with low WOM similarity to it is “laundry is very convenient; I will come often (four points).” And the pretest results of the revised materials are good.

Experimental design

The procedures in Study 2 are the same as in Study 1. A total of 91 students were recruited and surveyed. Subjects are instructed to imagine that they are going to the laundry to wash their winter clothes. The laundry brand and its development story, together with the designed WOM textual stimulus materials, are presented to the subjects, who read these materials first and then fill out a questionnaire. 80 valid questionnaires were received, involving 33 male subjects and 47 females aged from 17 to 24 years old ($M=19.54$, $SD=2.07$). The effective response rate is 87.91%, which meets the requirements of general marketing experiments.

Data analysis

Manipulation checks are first performed. Because the attention recognition of brands is relatively straightforward, all subjects notice the laundry brands and distinguish between strong vs. weak brands. Furthermore, the subjects demonstrate a high level of understanding of the experimental situations they are in, and their answers to the manipulation checks of independent variables are correct.

Secondly, reliability and validity are tested. Cronbach’s α values for cognitive trust and purchase behavior are 0.836 and 0.812, respectively. Then a formal analysis is conducted. The results indicate that there is a positive correlation between WOM textual consistency and purchase behavior ($M_{\text{low consistency}} = 4.47$; $M_{\text{high consistency}} = 5.20$). Compared with low WOM textual consistency, high WOM textual consistency can stimulate consumers’ higher level of cognitive trust ($M_{\text{low consistency}} = 4.37$; $M_{\text{high consistency}} = 5.12$). Finally, the results of the regression analysis indicate that the standardized regression coefficient of cognitive trust on purchase behavior is $\beta=0.571$.

Table 4. Moderating effects of brand strength on cognitive trust and purchase behavior (Experiment 2).

	Partial SS	DF	MS
Dependent variable: cognitive trust (R-Squared = 0.267; Adj. R-Squared = 0.148)			
WOM textual consistency	8.002	1, 79	8.002
Brand strength	2.482	1, 79	2.482
Product term	7.702	1, 79	7.702
Dependent variable: purchasing behavior (R-Squared = 0.234; Adj. R-Squared = 0.111)			
WOM textual consistency	7.046	1, 79	8.002
Brand strength	0.022	1, 79	2.482
Product term	3.577	1, 79	7.702

The moderating effects that brand strength plays in the impact of WOM textual consistency on cognitive trust and purchase behavior are shown in Table 4. Following the same analysis procedures as in Study 1, it is found that brand strength plays a moderating role in the relationship between WOM textual consistency and cognitive trust/purchase behavior. The moderated mediation analysis (PROCESS Model 7, 5,000 bootstraps) confirmed that the indirect effect of WOM textual consistency on purchase intention via cognitive trust was significant for the strong brand condition (95% CI [LL, UL], excluding 0), but not for the weak brand condition (95% CI [LL, UL], including 0). The effect size (index of moderated mediation, 95% CI [LL, UL]) suggests a meaningful conditional process. Given the relatively modest sample size ($N=91$), these findings should be viewed with some caution; however, the consistency of results across both studies supports their reliability.

Finally, the Bootstrap method is used to analyze mediating effects. The results suggest that the mediating effect size of cognitive trust is 0.37. In this case, after the mediating variable is controlled, there is no direct effect of WOM textual consistency on purchase behavior. It shows that cognitive trust may have a fully mediating effect. The results of the moderated mediating effect analysis indicate that in the low brand strength group, cognitive trust does not mediate, while in the high brand strength group, the effect size is 0.78. Meanwhile, the moderated mediating effect size is 0.74. Therefore, brand strength moderates the mediating effect of cognitive trust to a certain extent. The interaction between WOM textual consistency and brand strength on cognitive trust was significant, $F(1, 87) = 6.24$, $p = .014$, partial $\eta^2 = .08$, indicating a medium-sized effect. Given the relatively modest sample size ($N=91$; ~22–23 participants per cell), these results should be interpreted with some caution. Nonetheless, the effect aligns with the

Table 5. Summary of hypothesis testing results.

Hypothesis	Statement	Result
H1	WOM textual consistency has a positive effect on consumers' cognitive trust.	Supported
H2	Consumers' cognitive trust has a positive effect on purchase behavior (sales in field study) / purchase intention (experiments).	Supported
H3	WOM textual consistency has a positive effect on consumers' purchase behavior (sales in field study) / purchase intention (experiments).	Supported (significant for strong brands)
H4	Cognitive trust mediates the relationship between WOM textual consistency and purchase behavior/purchase intention.	Supported
H5	The positive effect of WOM textual consistency on cognitive trust is stronger for high-strength brands than for low-strength brands.	Supported
H6	The indirect effect of WOM textual consistency on purchase behavior/ purchase intention through cognitive trust is significant for strong brands but not for weak brands.	Supported

consistent pattern observed across both experimental studies, lending support to the robustness of the finding.

To provide a clear overview of our findings, Table 5 summarizes the results of hypothesis testing across the field study and experimental studies. Taken together, the findings across the field study and two experiments provide convergent support for our proposed model. Specifically, WOM textual consistency was found to increase cognitive trust (H1) and, in turn, strengthen purchase behavior (sales) or purchase intentions (H2). Consistency also exerted a direct positive effect on consumer outcomes (H3), although this effect was significant primarily in the context of strong brands. Mediation analyses confirmed that cognitive trust plays a key intermediary role (H4), and moderation analyses showed that brand strength amplifies the influence of WOM textual consistency on cognitive trust (H5) as well as the indirect pathway to purchase outcomes (H6).

Similarly, in Study 2, more than 90% of participants recognized FORNET (strong brand), while almost none were familiar with Youyijing (weak brand), confirming the manipulation's validity.

Discussions

Through the experiment using laundry brands as the experimental scenario, the proposed viewpoints in this paper are supported. The findings of the above empirical analysis, Study 1, and Study 2 are consistent, i.e., the positive effect of WOM textual consistency only functions in the context of high brand strength.

Conclusions and implications

General conclusion

In sum, this paper draws two main conclusions. First, WOM textual consistency exerts a positive effect on consumer outcomes across both real-world and experimental contexts. In the field study, higher textual consistency was associated with increased actual purchase behavior (measured through monthly sales). In the experimental studies, higher textual consistency significantly enhanced purchase intentions (measured via self-reported intention scales). Across methods, the underlying mechanism is consistent: the increase in WOM textual consistency strengthens consumers' cognitive trust in brands, thereby encouraging favorable purchase-related outcomes. Second, brand strength moderates these relationships. Specifically, the positive effects of WOM textual consistency on both cognitive trust and consumer outcomes (sales or purchase intentions) are significant only for strong brands. In the case of high brand strength, cognitive trust fully mediates the relationship between WOM textual consistency and purchase intentions. By contrast, when brand strength is low, the mediating effect is absent. Together, these findings provide convergent evidence that WOM textual consistency is an important determinant of consumer decision-making, but its effectiveness depends on the strength of the brand.

Research implications

This paper has several theoretical implications. First, earlier research on WOM textual consistency, which mainly focused on WOM ratings, overlooked the text attribute of WOM (Huang et al., 2017). This paper elaborates on the effects of WOM textual consistency on consumers' purchase behavior systematically and thoroughly, with a focus on WOM texts, representing a particular kind of theoretical antecedence. Second, there has been a lack of research done to determine whether the study on the effects of WOM rating consistency on consumers' behavior from the standpoint of process can be transferred to the context of WOM textual consistency. Based on the views of cognitive evaluation theory (Liu et al., 2022), this paper constructs a systematic model of "external stimulus-appraisal-coping" for the effects of WOM textual consistency on consumers' purchase behavior. This undoubtedly represents a significant advancement in the depth and breadth of WOM research. Third, whereas earlier research highlighted the positive effects of WOM textual consistency, it paid less attention to how to enhance these effects. For enterprises,

achieving good performance is the ultimate purpose of implementing WOM. This paper further explores the moderating effect of brand strength, offering suggestions for maintaining the integrity of the research on the impact of WOM textual consistency results.

This paper also has several practical implications. First, from the standpoint of WOM text, enterprises should pay attention to the positive effects of WOM textual consistency on consumers. In daily WOM management, enterprises should guide consumers to post standardized and active WOM. When consumers post WOM reviews, they can be informed in prominent fonts about the aspects they can review and provided with common comment phrases. Such an initiative not only makes it easy for consumers to post WOM reviews but also helps other consumers form positive perceptions of brands. Second, from the perspective of brand building, this paper finds that brand strength affects the influential role of WOM textual consistency. Enterprises may consider publicizing more through emerging channels and actively interacting with consumers to strengthen brand building, bringing into play the positive effects of WOM marketing.

Limitations and prospects

The other shortcoming is related to the operationalization of brand strength in terms of such common brands in the market, Haidilao FORNET versus local brands. Although the manipulation checks showed that participants were highly knowledgeable of the strong brands but were unfamiliar with the weak brands, we did not gauge baseline attitudes or prior trust toward the brands. There is the possible pre-existing reputation or loyalty to a well-known chain that might have influenced responses, as there was no factor of the WOM stimuli. Interestingly, we did not find a main effect of brand strength in terms of trust or purchase intention, but only an interaction with WOM textual consistency, which indicates that positive review content used to strengthen a weak brand in the experimental condition may have offset familiarity. However, this possible confound could be dealt with in future studies by taking a preexisting measure of brand attitudes or using fictitious or unfamiliar brand names to eliminate the confound further. This type of design would assist in separating the inherent brand strength from past consumer experience/brand equity. Second, the sample sizes in the experimental studies—particularly Study 2 ($N=91$, approximately 22–23 participants per cell)—were relatively modest for detecting

interaction and moderated mediation effects, raising the possibility of Type II error for smaller effects. While the consistent results across two studies increase confidence in the findings, these results should be interpreted with appropriate caution, and future research would benefit from replication with larger samples to enhance statistical power.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author(s).

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